Andhra. When inscribing Ashoka's message there, he made part of it bidirectional. This segment is boustrophedonic, a form of writing often found in the remains of ancient Greece in which the lines, rather than following one direction, turn right to left and left to right.[16] Was this unnamed scribe using the rock surface to suggest that he was familiar with other writing systems? Kharoshthi was the only regional script written from right to left, so was the engraver indicating his possession of a more cosmopolitan knowledge of scripts? And why did he give up writing in this way after a few lines? The rest of the text, in fact, was rather haphazardly put down on the remaining space, with no concession to readability at all.[17] There is no clear answer to why he engraved the message in this way. What can certainly be said is that every official who expected to read or translate this engraving would, instead of marvelling at the engraver's skill, have roundly cursed the fellow for his rotten cursive. Boustrophedon is not exactly easy on the eye at the best of times.

Apart from such epigraphic quirks, which occasionally bring alive engravers and writers, some changes were made at the level of the locality so that the identity of the emperor sending out the message was easily apprehended. The emperor himself evidently imagined that his subjects would recognize him by his titles alone. 'Devanampiya' (dear to the gods) or 'Devanampiya Piyadasi' (dear to the gods and one who looks affectionately or amiably) was how the emperor was alluded to in the bulk of these edicts. In some provinces, though, the administrators in charge of propagating his message added the king's name to it. At places like Maski in Karnataka and at Gujjara in Central India, this king is mentioned by name as 'Ashoka' and 'Ashoka raja', respectively. In all likelihood the local administrator believed that the people hearing or reading the words needed clarity on the identity of Devanampiya.

The quality and the quirks of writers and engravers, and what was inadvertently or consciously added to the epigraphic text by local officials,